

Word family: **society / societies / societal / social / socially**

Base word: society

Plural: societies

Closely related forms: societal, social, socially

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / related adjectives and adverb (相關形容詞及副詞)

Your sentence:

> "...it appears to tell the bigger story of how human beings developed, cooperated, and built **societies**."

Meaning in this passage

Here, **societies** means **organized communities of people who live together under shared systems, customs, institutions, and relationships**.

The plural is important: the sentence is talking about different human communities and civilizations that developed over history.

繁體中文： 由人們共同生活並形成制度、規範、文化及社會關係的有組織人類群體

中文翻譯：

> "...how human beings developed, cooperated, and built **societies**."

「.....人類如何發展、如何合作，以及如何建立不同的**社會 / 文明社群**。」

Here:

build societies = 建立有制度、文化、規範和人際關係結構的人類社會

1. **society = human community as an organized system (社會) — 社會；人類社會**

This is the central meaning behind your passage.

Meaning: People living together in an organized community with shared institutions, customs, laws, relationships, and ways of life.

Practice 1 — Original

> "Human beings gradually built complex **societies**."

「人類逐漸建立了複雜的**社會**。」

Practice 2

> “Education plays an important role in **society**.”

「教育在**社會**中扮演重要角色。」

Practice 3

> “Technology has changed modern **society**.”

「科技改變了現代**社會**。」

society = 人們共同生活並透過制度、文化、法律及人際關係形成的整體社會系統

Common:

- * modern society
- * human society
- * society as a whole
- * society changes
- * society develops

2. **a society** = a particular community/civilization (特定社會) — 某個社會；社群；文明

Society can be countable when referring to one particular organized human community.

This is especially relevant to your plural:

> **societies**

Practice 4

> “Ancient **societies** developed different systems of government.”

「古代不同的**社會 / 文明**發展出不同的治理制度。」

Practice 5

> “Every **society** has its own customs.”

「每個**社會**都有自己的習俗。」

a society = 某一個具有共同制度、文化和生活方式的人類社會

This is closely related to Meaning 1, but the countability contrast is important:

> **society** = 社會整體 / 社會這種制度

> **a society** = 一個特定社會

For strict semantic counting, I would keep these under the same broad core concept but display both separately for learners.

3. **society** = organization/association (組織) — 學會 ; 協會 ; 社團

Society can mean an organized group of people who share an interest, profession, cause, or purpose.

Practice 6

> “She joined the university history **society**.”

「她加入了大學的歷史**學會 / 社團**。」

Practice 7

> “The medical **society** holds an annual conference.”

「該醫學**學會**每年舉辦一次會議。」

society = 為共同興趣、專業、研究或目標而成立的正式組織或社團

Common:

* historical society

* medical society

* scientific society

* student society

* debating society

This is a genuinely distinct core meaning.

4. **society** = upper-class social world (上流社會) — 上流社會 ; 社交名流圈

Society can refer specifically to wealthy, socially prominent, or traditionally elite social circles.

Practice 8

> “She became well known in London **society**.”

「她在倫敦**上流社會 / 社交名流圈**中變得很有名。」

Practice 9

> “The event attracted members of high **society**.”

「這場活動吸引了**上流社會**人士參加。」

society = 富裕、有社會地位或經常參與高端社交活動的人群

Common:

- * high society
- * society wedding
- * society circles

This is distinct from general “society.”

5. **society** = social interaction/company of other people (陪伴 / 交往) — 社交 ; 陪伴

There is also an older/literary use in expressions such as:

> “He enjoys the society of intelligent people.”

meaning:

> 他喜歡與有智慧的人交往 / 相處。

Here, **society** means **company or companionship**.

This sense still exists, but it is considerably less common in modern everyday English.

For your database, I would mark it as:

lower-priority / literary

rather than include it in the main core count.

Related form: **societal**

Societal means relating to society as a whole, especially its structures or problems.

Practice 10

> “The report examines major **societal** changes.”

「這份報告探討重大的**社會層面變化**。」

Practice 11

> “Housing inequality is a **societal** issue.”

「住房不平等是一個**社會層面的問題**。」

societal = 與整個社會的結構、制度或問題有關的

This word is more formal than **social**.

Related form: **social**

Social is extremely important and has developed several meanings of its own.

social = relating to society (社會的)

Practice 12

> “The book examines major **social** changes.”

「這本書探討重大的**社會變化**。」

social = 與社會、人群及人與人之間的關係有關的

social = involving interaction with other people (社交的)

Practice 13

> “She has a very active **social** life.”

「她的**社交生活**非常活躍。」

Practice 14

> “The event was mainly **social**.”

「這場活動主要是**社交性質**的。」

social = 與和別人見面、交流、共同活動有關的

Related form: **socially**

Practice 15

> “The behaviour is **socially** acceptable.”

「這種行為在**社會上**是可以接受的。」

Practice 16

> “He is very active **socially**.”

「他在**社交方面**非常活躍。」

socially can therefore mean:

* from society's point of view

* in terms of social interaction

Important distinction: **society vs community**

society

usually emphasizes the **larger organized system** of people, institutions, values, and relationships.

community

usually emphasizes a group connected by:

* location

* identity

* shared interest

* shared experience

- > modern society
- > local community

A community is often smaller and more directly connected.

Important distinction: **society vs culture**

society

= the organized group of people and their institutions/relationships

culture

= the beliefs, customs, values, arts, traditions, and practices associated with a group

So:

> a society **has** a culture

although in everyday language the two often overlap.

Important distinction: **society vs civilization**

society

is broader and can refer to virtually any organized human community.

civilization

often refers to a large, historically developed society with complex institutions, culture, technology, cities, etc.

So in your sentence:

> **built societies**

is broader and more neutral than:

> **built civilizations**

Important distinction: **society vs population**

population

means the people living in a particular area, considered numerically or demographically.

society

includes the relationships, institutions, rules, and structures connecting those people.

A population is not automatically the same concept as a society.

Important distinction: **social vs societal**

These two are related but not identical.

social

is much broader:

- * social problems
- * social interaction
- * social life
- * social skills

societal

specifically means:

> affecting or relating to society as a whole

So:

> societal change

usually sounds more structural and formal than:

> social change

Countability note

This is particularly important for **society**.

Uncountable/general

> “Society expects people to follow certain rules.”

「**社會**期望人們遵守某些規則。」

Here, **society** means society generally.

Countable/specific

> “Ancient Rome was a complex **society**.”

「古羅馬是一個複雜的**社會**。」

> “Different **societies** developed different traditions.”

「不同的**社會**發展出不同傳統。」

This is the pattern used in your passage.

Countable organization

> “She joined a scientific **society**.”

「她加入了一個科學**學會**。」

Same word, but a completely different sense.

Useful construction: **society as a whole** — **整個社會**

Practice 17

> “The change could benefit **society as a whole**.”

「這項改變可能使**整個社會**受益。」

This belongs to Meaning 1.

Useful expression: ****high society — 上流社會****

Practice 18

> “The family moved in ****high society****.”

「這個家庭活躍於****上流社會****。」

This belongs to Meaning 4.

Family-extension note

The practical family includes:

* ****society****
* ****societies****
* ****societal****
* ****social****
* ****socially****

There are more distant relatives such as ****sociology****, ****sociological****, ****sociologist****, ****socialize/socialise****, and ****sociable****, but these have developed sufficiently independent meanings that I would treat them as lexical-family extensions rather than automatically folding them into the core ****society**** entry.

This follows the broader curation principle of sweeping the family generously while keeping independently developed words accurately labelled rather than pretending they are additional senses of the base noun.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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society — organized human community/system	人們共同生活並透過制度、文化、規範及關係形成的整體社會
a society — particular society	某一個具有共同制度、文化和生活方式的特定人類社會
society — association	為共同興趣、專業、研究或目標成立的學會、協會或社團
society — elite social circle	富裕或有社會地位人士組成的上流社會 / 名流圈
society — companionship	與他人相處、交往或陪伴；較文學 / 低頻

societal	與整個社會的結構、制度或問題有關的		
social	社會的；亦可表示社交的		
socially	在社會層面上；在社交方面		

For your original sentence

> “...how human beings developed, cooperated, and built **societies**.”

The exact meaning is:

societies = 人類共同建立的有組織群體，其中存在制度、文化、規範和持續的社會關係

So:

> **built societies**

= **建立社會 / 形成有組織的人類社群**

The plural **societies** emphasizes that humans did not develop one single universal society; different groups formed different organized social systems.

For your database, I would count **3 genuinely useful core meanings** for **society**:

1. **human society / a particular organized human community**
2. **an association or organized group for a shared purpose**
3. **high society / socially elite circles**

I would treat **uncountable society vs countable a society** as an important grammatical distinction within #1 rather than two separate meanings, and keep the old companionship sense as lower-priority rather than inflate the modern core count.